

Open Card Game Rules Reference

Original write-ups of traditional and popular card games

15 games for 1 to 8 players, playable with the decks you already own.

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SOLITAIRE (1 PLAYER)

FreeCell

Also known as	Free Cell, FreeCell Solitaire
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	10-30 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Take one 52-card deck without jokers, shuffle it, and deal the whole pack face up into eight tableau columns: seven cards each to the first four columns and six each to the last four. Spread each column so that every card in it stays readable, with the last card of the column fully exposed.

Above or beside the tableau, set out four free cells on one side and four foundation spaces on the other. All eight start empty.

That is the entire layout. There is no stock, no waste and no redeal, and nothing is dealt face down. From the first move to the last you are working with complete information, which is what separates FreeCell from Klondike and Spider. No new card can turn up, so a deal is a puzzle that is already either solvable or not before you touch it.

Play

The foundations are built up in suit from the ace to the king, one foundation per suit. The tableau columns are built down in alternating colours, so a black jack accepts a red 10 and that red 10 accepts a black 9.

Strictly speaking exactly one card moves at a time, and it has to be either the exposed card at the end of a column or a card sitting in a free cell. You can send it to:

- a foundation, if it is the next rank up in that suit;
- a tableau column whose end card is one rank higher and the opposite colour;
- an empty free cell, which holds exactly one card and imposes no other condition;
- an empty column, which accepts any single card at all. Unlike Klondike, empty columns are not reserved for kings, and this is the most powerful resource in the game.

A card parked in a free cell is fully available and can be played out again to a column or a foundation whenever it fits. The only cost of using a cell is that it is no longer free for manoeuvring.

Almost every version lets you drag a whole run at once, which is the supermove, also called a power move. It is not a separate rule. It is shorthand for a run of ordinary single-card moves that the software performs for you: the upper cards of the run get shuffled into free cells and empty columns, the bottom card is moved, and the run is rebuilt on top of it. The number of cards you can shift this way is therefore capped by the workspace you have:

maximum cards = (1 + empty free cells) × 2^(empty columns)

With two cells open and no empty columns you can move three cards. With all four cells open and one empty column you can move ten. There is one catch: if the destination is itself an

empty column, that column cannot double as workspace, so leave it out of the exponent. Moving into your only empty column with all four cells free gets you five cards, not ten.

The run you are moving must already be a proper descending, alternating-colour sequence. A stack that merely sits together is not movable as a block, and if you do not have the storage for the whole run you have to break it up by hand.

Taking a card back off a foundation into the tableau is allowed in most implementations and is occasionally the move that saves a deal, but some versions lock a foundation once a card is played there, so check before you count on it.

The deal ends when all four foundations reach their kings, or when you are stuck: every free cell occupied, no empty column, and no exposed card that fits anywhere.

Goal & scoring

You win by moving all 52 cards onto the foundations, each suit in order from ace up to king. FreeCell keeps no points in its traditional form. A deal is won or lost, and players who want a finer measure compare move counts or elapsed time on the same numbered deal rather than tallying a score.

The interesting number in FreeCell is how often a deal can be won at all. Because every card is visible and four cells is a generous allowance, nearly every deal has a solution: solvers put it at roughly 99.999 percent of random deals. Microsoft's original set of 32,000 numbered deals contains exactly one that has been proven impossible, deal 11,982, and establishing that took a volunteer effort running through the mid-1990s. When the same generator was extended to a million deals, only eight unwinnable ones turned up in total: 11,982, 146,692, 186,216, 455,889, 495,505, 512,118, 517,776 and 781,948.

Losing a FreeCell deal is therefore almost always your mistake rather than the shuffle's, which is both the appeal and the cruelty of the game. Solvable does not mean easy, though. Deals 617 and 1,941 from the original set are notorious, and 1,941 is widely nominated as the hardest solvable deal among the 32,000. Working through the numbered deals in order is a long-running informal challenge.

Variants

Baker's Game — The game FreeCell was derived from. Identical layout and identical four free cells, but the tableau builds down in suit instead of alternating colours. Removing colour-based landing spots roughly halves the places any card can go, and winnability drops from near-certainty to somewhere around three quarters of deals, so a lost game here is much less likely to be your fault.

Eight Off — Eight free cells rather than four. Deal 48 cards into eight columns of six, then place the remaining four cards one each into four of the eight cells, leaving four cells open. The tableau builds down in suit, and only a king may be moved into an empty column. The extra cells are compensation for both of those tighter restrictions.

Seahaven Towers — Fifty cards go into ten columns of five, and the last two cards are placed into two of the four free cells, leaving two open. The tableau builds down in suit and only kings may fill an empty column. With ten short columns, two occupied cells and no colour alternation, it plays much more tightly than FreeCell and rewards planning several moves ahead.

ForeCell — Deal four cards face up into the four free cells first, then 48 cards into eight columns of six. You start with every cell full, so your first job is emptying them. The tableau

builds down in alternating colours as in FreeCell, but only a king may be moved into an empty column, which removes the escape hatch that makes standard FreeCell so forgiving.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Laboratory, Solitaire Central, BVS Solitaire, PlayFreeCellOnline, Freecell Solver documentation (Shlomi Fish). Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Golf

Also known as	Golf Solitaire, Golf Patience, One Foundation
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	5-15 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck. Deal 35 cards face up into seven columns of five. Overlap the cards in each column so every rank stays readable, with the last card dealt to a column sitting at the exposed end. All 35 are visible from the start, so nothing is hidden. The 17 cards left over become the stock, kept face down in a single pile. Turn the top stock card face up beside it to start the waste pile, which is the one pile you will build on for the rest of the deal. That leaves 16 cards in the stock. Leave room for the waste to grow, since in a good deal nearly the whole pack ends up there. There are no foundations by suit and no reserve; the seven columns, the stock, and the waste are the entire layout.

Play

Only the exposed card at the open end of each column is in play. The rest are locked until the cards covering them are gone.

On your turn you may move any one exposed column card onto the waste pile, provided its rank is exactly one higher or one lower than the current top card of the waste. Suits and colours are ignored entirely. If the waste shows a 9, you may play any 8 or any 10. Moving a card exposes the one behind it in that column, which may then be playable in turn, so a single well-placed card can start a long chain.

Ranks do not wrap in the standard game. Aces are low and kings are high: only a 2 plays onto an ace, and only a queen plays onto a king. Playing an ace on a king, or a king on an ace, is illegal. This is the single rule that ends most deals, and the most commonly relaxed one.

You may keep making legal moves for as long as you like; you are never forced to draw. Cards never move between columns, never move back off the waste, and never go onto the stock. Once a column is emptied the gap stays empty for the rest of the deal, and nothing may be placed there.

When you are stuck, or simply choose to, turn the next card of the stock face up onto the waste. That card becomes the new build card regardless of what it covers, so a draw can reset the sequence to any rank. Drawing is the only way to change the top of the waste other than playing a column card.

The deal ends when the stock is empty and no exposed column card can legally be played onto the waste. There is no redeal and no shuffling of the waste back into the stock. If you have cleared all 35 column cards you have holed out; otherwise the deal is over with cards still on the table.

A separate multiplayer game is also called Golf. That one is usually played as Six-Card Golf, where each player manages a private face-down grid, swapping and discarding to reach the lowest total over nine deals. The two games share only the golf scoring metaphor and are

otherwise unrelated; the rules here are for the single-player patience.

Goal & scoring

The object of a single deal is to clear all 35 cards out of the seven columns and onto the waste. Cards left in the stock do not matter.

Score as in golf: count one stroke for every card still stranded in the columns when the deal ends. Clearing the tableau scores zero for the hole, and a common house rule lets you go under par by subtracting one for each card still face down in the stock when you hole out.

A full round is nine deals, one per hole, with the strokes added up. Under strict no-wraparound rules most deals cannot be cleared, so a nine-hole total in the mid-thirties is a solid round and anything at or below par of about 45 is respectable. Two rounds of nine make an eighteen-hole match.

Variants

Putt Putt (wraparound) — Ranks wrap, so a king may be played on an ace and an ace on a king, making the sequence a continuous loop. This removes the dead ends that spoil most strict deals and lifts the win rate dramatically, which is why nearly every computer version offers it as an easy mode.

Relaxed stock — Allow one redeal: gather the waste after the stock runs out, turn it over without shuffling, and use it as a fresh stock. Some house rules instead let you undo the last move or deal a shorter tableau of six columns of five, leaving 22 cards in the stock. All of these trade difficulty for a better chance of holing out.

Black Hole — David Parlett's rework. Deal 17 fans of three cards around the ace of spades, which sits alone in the centre as the only foundation. Build up or down on it with wraparound, taking the exposed card of any fan, and there is no stock at all. Everything is visible from the start, so it plays as a puzzle rather than a gamble, and the great majority of deals are solvable.

All in a Row — Also by Parlett. The whole deck is dealt into 13 overlapping fans of four cards in a single row, with no stock and no starting foundation card. The first card you take becomes the base of the waste and you build up or down with wraparound from there, aiming to absorb all 52 cards.

Double Golf — Two shuffled decks are used, dealt into a wider tableau such as eight columns of eight, with the remainder as stock. Play is otherwise identical. Duplicated ranks give more branching options, but the larger layout means a single dead run can still leave a heavy score.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Central Rulebook, Solitaire Laboratory, Wikibooks Solitaire card games, Parlett Games, Bicycle Cards. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Klondike

Also known as	Solitaire, Patience, Klondike Solitaire, Canfield
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	5-20 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Use a single 52-card deck with the jokers removed. Shuffle, then build seven tableau piles from left to right: one card in the first pile, two in the second, on up to seven in the seventh, for 28 cards in total. The tidy way to deal it is one card to each pile in a left-to-right sweep, skipping any pile that already holds its full count. Turn the exposed card of every pile face up and leave everything under it face down.

Above the tableau, reserve four spaces for the foundations. They start empty. The 24 cards you did not deal go face down in a single packet as the stock, with an empty space beside it for the waste. There is no dealer to choose and no opponent, so play begins the moment the layout is built.

Play

There are two places to build. The four foundations go up in suit starting from the ace: move an ace up as soon as one is exposed, then the 2 of that suit, and so on through the king. The seven tableau piles go down in alternating colours, so a red 9 accepts a black 8, and that black 8 accepts a red 7.

Playable cards are the exposed card at the outer end of each tableau pile and the top card of the waste. You may move one of those to a foundation, or to a tableau pile whose exposed card is one rank higher and the opposite colour. You may also lift a properly ordered run of face-up tableau cards and move it as a unit onto a card that continues the sequence. Most rule sets let you take just the lower portion of a run; stricter ones make you move the whole face-up group or nothing.

Any time a move leaves a face-down card at the end of a tableau pile, turn it up immediately.

Empty columns carry the one real restriction: only a king, or a run headed by a king, may be moved into a column you have cleared. Nothing else may go there, so emptying a column with no king in sight usually wastes the space.

When you run out of tableau moves, work the stock. Turn cards face up onto the waste and play from there. Only the top card of the waste is ever playable, and it leaves one card at a time. How many cards you turn per go is the setting that defines the two common versions.

Draw one: turn a single card at a time. Every card in the stock reaches the top of the waste on every pass, so nothing stays out of reach and the game is far more forgiving.

Draw three: turn three at once, overlapped so you can read all three but only the outermost is playable. The two behind it become available only after the card in front of them is played. Because the stock is consumed in blocks of three, roughly two thirds of it is unreachable at any given moment, and every card you take shifts which cards surface on the next pass. This is the older and harder default.

When the stock runs out, turn the waste over without shuffling to form a new stock. That is a redeal, and its limit is the other point players argue about. Casual play generally allows unlimited redeals in both draw modes. Scored and timed versions cap it: three passes through the stock, meaning two redeals, is the usual draw-three convention, while draw one and Vegas scoring are often played with a single pass and no redeal at all. Settle the limit before you deal.

Taking the top card back off a foundation into the tableau is permitted in most rule sets and is sometimes the only way to free a card you need, though scored versions charge you for it and a few rule sets forbid it outright.

The deal ends when all four foundations are complete, or when you are stuck: nothing playable from any tableau pile, nothing playable off the waste, and no redeal left.

Goal & scoring

You win by getting all 52 cards onto the foundations, each suit built ace through king. Most people simply play win or lose and keep no score.

Standard scoring, the system most software uses, awards 5 points for moving a card from the waste to the tableau, 10 for moving a card to a foundation, and 5 for turning up a face-down tableau card. Pulling a card back from a foundation costs 15. Recycling the stock costs points once you are past the first pass, commonly 20 in draw three and a steeper charge in draw one, where an extra pass is worth much more. Timed play adds a bonus that grows the faster you finish.

Vegas scoring treats the deal as a wager. You buy the deck for 52 units, one per card, and collect 5 units for every card you land on a foundation, so eleven cards puts you 3 ahead and break-even is closer than it looks. You normally get one pass through the stock, and many players carry a running bankroll from deal to deal.

Klondike is not always winnable, which matters more than beginners expect. Exhaustive computer analysis of draw-three Klondike with every face-down card revealed in advance puts the ceiling at about 82 percent of deals, so roughly one deal in six cannot be won by anyone regardless of skill. Draw one is more winnable than that. Playing blind, as you actually do, real results are much lower: large samples of players come in near a third of games at draw one and around one game in ten at draw three.

Variants

Vegas Klondike — Klondike played as a bet. You pay 52 units for the deck, one per card, and earn 5 units for each card you get onto a foundation, so eleven cards is break-even plus a little. Only one pass through the stock is allowed, with no redeal, which makes the draw-three version brutal. Many players keep a cumulative bankroll across a session instead of settling each deal separately.

Thoughtful Klondike — Identical to ordinary Klondike except that the identity of every face-down card is known from the start. It is mostly a research construct: because the only difference is information, any deal solvable in Thoughtful Klondike is solvable in Klondike too, so solving it gives an upper bound on how often the real game can be won. This is where the roughly 82 percent figure for draw three comes from.

Double Klondike — Two decks, 104 cards, nine tableau piles dealt one through nine, and eight foundations, two per suit. Building rules are unchanged: foundations up in suit from the ace, tableau down in alternating colours, kings only into empty columns. The extra piles make it

noticeably easier to win than single-deck Klondike. The name is also used for a two-player race in which each player has their own tableau but both feed a shared set of foundations.

Whitehead — The same 28-card, seven-pile layout as Klondike, but everything is dealt face up so there is nothing hidden. The tableau builds down in matching colour rather than alternating colour, red on red and black on black. Only runs that are entirely of one suit may be moved as a block, and an empty column will take any card or run, not just a king.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Laboratory, GameRules.com, Solitaired, Solitaire.com, BVS Solitaire, Solitaire winnability study (Blake and Gent). Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Pyramid

Also known as	Pyramid Solitaire, Solitaire Thirteen, Pile of Twenty-Eight
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	5-15 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck and build the pyramid face up in seven rows. Lay one card at the top, then two below it, then three, and so on down to a bottom row of seven, for 28 cards in all. Offset each row so that every card rests on and partly covers the two cards above it, and so that each card in turn is partly covered by the two below it. Only the seven cards of the bottom row start out completely uncovered.

The remaining 24 cards form the stock, squared up face down to one side. Leave space next to it for a waste pile and space somewhere clear for discards. Ranks count as numbers throughout: ace is 1, jack is 11, queen is 12, king is 13, and every other card is its face value. Suit and colour never matter.

Play

A card is available only when nothing overlaps it. In the pyramid that means both cards below it have already been removed. The bottom row is available from the start; each removal frees the cards above once their other supporter also goes.

Remove available cards in pairs that add to exactly 13. The pairings are ace with queen, 2 with jack, 3 with 10, 4 with 9, 5 with 8, and 6 with 7. Kings are worth 13 on their own, so any available king is removed by itself at any time. Removed cards are set aside for good and never come back into play.

Both cards of a pair must be available at the moment you take them, but they need not be in the same place. You may pair two uncovered pyramid cards, or one pyramid card with the top card of the waste. Two pyramid cards that sit side by side in the same row can be paired normally, since neither covers the other. What you cannot do is use a card that is still covered, however visible its rank is.

When you want a new card, turn the top card of the stock face up onto the waste. Only the top of the waste is live; the cards under it are buried until it is played. Play the turned card immediately if you can, or leave it and turn another. The card you just turned may be paired with the previous top of the waste, so two consecutive stock cards summing to 13 clear each other.

Draw at your own pace, and take any legal removal at any time. There is no obligation to draw when useful pairings remain on the table, and holding a convenient card on top of the waste while you work through the pyramid is a normal tactic.

In the standard game you get one pass through the stock and no redeal. The deal ends when the stock is exhausted and no further pair can be removed. Since a card buried in the waste is gone for the rest of the deal under those rules, the order in which you spend stock cards matters more than anything else you do.

Goal & scoring

You win by dismantling the whole pyramid: all 28 cards removed. Cards left in the stock or waste are ignored, so clearing the last pyramid card wins immediately even with a stack of unused cards beside you.

The traditional game keeps no score beyond won or lost. Under the strict single-pass rules a clear is genuinely uncommon, and a great many deals are unwinnable no matter how well you play, so judging yourself on wins per session is fairer than judging a single deal.

If you want a score, the usual convention is a penalty of one point per card left in the pyramid, tallied over several deals with the lowest total best. Computer versions often add time bonuses and streak bonuses on top, which is a house scoring layer rather than part of the game.

Variants

Three passes — After the stock runs out, turn the waste over without shuffling to make a new stock and go again. Two redeals, for three passes in total, is the most common relaxed setting and the one most computer versions default to. It rescues cards buried early in the first pass and raises the win rate substantially.

Draw three — Turn stock cards three at a time instead of one, with only the top of each triple available, and allow unlimited redeals to compensate. Sold as King Tut or Tut's Tomb in various solitaire collections. Buried cards become reachable eventually, but you have far less control over which card is showing at any given moment.

Giza — An open variant by Michael Keller. The pyramid is dealt as usual, but the 24 leftover cards go face up into eight piles of three instead of a face-down stock, with the top card of each pile available. Nothing is hidden and there is no drawing, so the deal is a pure planning puzzle that you either solve or do not.

Apophis — Deal the standard 28-card pyramid, then run the stock into three separate waste piles instead of one, choosing which pile each turned card goes on. The top card of all three piles is available at once, which gives you three live cards to work with and much better control over what you keep in reach.

Clear everything — A harder scoring condition rather than a different layout: you must remove all 52 cards, stock and waste included, not just the pyramid. Very few deals can be beaten this way, so it is best treated as an occasional challenge rather than the default.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Central Rulebook, Wikibooks Solitaire card games, BVS Solitaire, Bicycle Cards, PlayingCardDecks. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Spider

Also known as	Spider Solitaire, Spider Patience
Players	1 player
Deck	2 standard decks (104 cards); the easier settings replace the pack with repeated copies of one or two suits
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Spider is played with 104 cards, the equivalent of two standard decks. Which suits those cards come from is the difficulty setting. The four-suit game uses two full decks, two of each suit. The two-suit game uses four copies each of two suits, usually spades and hearts. The one-suit game uses eight copies of a single suit. With real cards you are effectively playing four-suit unless you go to the trouble of assembling a stripped pack, which is why the easier settings are mainly a computer thing.

Shuffle all 104 cards together and deal 54 of them into ten tableau columns: six cards each to the first four columns and five cards each to the remaining six. Deal them face down, then turn the exposed card of each column face up. The 50 cards left over become the stock, set aside face down. It will feed the tableau in five deals of ten.

There are no foundation piles to build on. Just leave a clear area beside the tableau for completed sequences, which come off the table intact. You will need room for eight of them.

Play

Everything happens in the tableau. Build columns downward by rank, and by rank alone: any 9 may be placed on any 10 whatever the suits. Aces are low and kings are high, so nothing can ever be placed on an ace, and a king can never be placed on another card.

Suit matters for moving, not for placing. You may always move the single exposed card at the end of a column. You may move several cards as a block only if they run in descending order and are all of the same suit. The 8, 7 and 6 of clubs travel together; a stack of club 8, heart 7, club 6 is a perfectly legal arrangement on the table but has to be taken apart one card at a time. That single restriction is what makes the multi-suit games hard, and it is the rule newcomers most often get wrong.

When a move uncovers a face-down card at the end of a column, turn it face up at once.

An empty column will accept any card, or any block you are allowed to move. Nothing is reserved for kings. Putting a king there is usually the strongest use of the space, though, since a column headed by a low card can only ever take a few more cards on top.

When you have no move worth making, deal from the stock: one card face up onto the end of every one of the ten columns, all at once. You may do this five times, which exactly exhausts the 50-card stock. There is one hard condition attached. Every column must contain at least one card before you deal. If any column is empty you cannot deal, and you have to fill it first, even with a single junk card. Players regularly lose games by clearing a column and then discovering they have locked themselves out of the stock, so plan the deal before you empty anything. Note also that a deal drops a card onto every column whether it helps or not, so it will usually bury

runs you were part way through assembling.

Whenever a full descending same-suit sequence from king down to ace sits at the end of a column, it is removed from the table and set aside. That sequence is finished and can never be touched again. Removing it exposes whatever was underneath, which is very often the real reason you built it.

The game ends when you have removed all eight sequences, or when the stock is empty and no remaining move gets you any closer.

Goal & scoring

You win by assembling and removing all eight complete king-to-ace sequences, each one entirely in a single suit, which clears every card off the table. Anything short of eight is a loss; there is no partial credit in casual play.

The scoring system carried by most software starts you at 500 points and takes off 1 point for every move you make, counting deals from the stock and counting undos. Each completed sequence you remove adds 100. A perfect game is therefore bounded above by 1,300, and real scores land well below that, since even efficient play burns hundreds of moves.

Not every deal can be won, and the suit setting changes the odds enormously. One-suit Spider is winnable nearly every time with careful play, with competent players reporting rates around 90 percent and higher. Two-suit is a real puzzle, with skilled play landing somewhere in the 30 to 40 percent range. Four-suit is the serious version: strong players usually win well under 20 percent of deals, and casual averages sit in the single digits. Unlike FreeCell, Spider has no authoritative exhaustive solvability study, so these numbers come from large samples of actual play rather than from solvers, and you should treat them as ballpark figures.

Variants

Spiderette — One deck, Klondike-shaped. Deal 28 cards into seven columns of one through seven, exposed card face up, and keep the other 24 as stock. Building, group movement and sequence removal follow Spider exactly, but you only need four king-to-ace suit sequences. The stock is dealt seven at a time, one card onto each column, and the last deal is short: three cards, going to the leftmost columns.

Will o' the Wisp — A faster one-deck Spider. Deal seven columns of three cards each, 21 in total, with only the exposed card of each column face up. The remaining 31 cards feed the tableau seven at a time. Everything else matches Spider, and four suit sequences win it. The shallow columns mean far less is hidden at the start, which makes it markedly kinder than Spiderette.

Black Widow — Spider with the group-move restriction dropped. Same two decks, same ten columns of six, six, five, and same five deals of ten from the stock, but any descending run may be picked up and moved as a block regardless of suit. Sequences still have to be all one suit to be removed, so the goal is unchanged. Removing the hardest rule in Spider makes this the easiest game in the family.

Simple Simon — One deck, no stock, nothing hidden. All 52 cards go face up into ten columns of eight, eight, eight, seven, six, five, four, three, two and one. Build down by rank ignoring suit, move blocks only when they are same-suit descending runs, and put any card into an empty column. Remove the four king-to-ace suit sequences to win. With no stock and full information it is a pure puzzle rather than a game of chance.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Semicolon Solitaire Rules, Solitaired, BVS Solitaire, SuitedGames, TrySolitaire, Solitaire Bliss. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

TRICK-TAKING

Hearts

Also known as	Black Lady, Chase the Lady, Black Widow
Players	3-6 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; a few low cards come out for 3, 5 or 6 players
Time	30-60 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

Hearts is at its best with four players, each on their own. There are no partnerships and no trump suit. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Aces are high and twos are low in every suit.

Pick a first dealer however you like, drawing for the low card being the usual method, then pass the deal one seat to the left after every hand. The dealer shuffles and deals the entire pack out one card at a time, clockwise, beginning with the player on their left. Four players get 13 cards each and the hand runs 13 tricks.

Other numbers need the pack trimmed so the deal comes out even. For three players, remove the 2 of diamonds and deal 17 each. For five, remove the 2 of diamonds and the 2 of clubs and deal 10 each. For six, remove the 2 of diamonds, the 2 and 3 of clubs and the 2 of spades and deal 8 each. The cards pulled are always low cards from the two suits that carry no penalties, so nothing about the scoring changes.

There is no layout, no stock and no discard pile. Everything sits in the players' hands, and there is nothing to write down until the first hand has been played out.

Play

Every hand opens with a pass. Pick three cards out of your hand and lay them face down in front of the player who is to receive them. Nobody may look at the cards coming their way until they have committed their own three, so the exchange is genuinely blind on both sides. The direction rotates deal by deal: pass to the left on the first hand, to the right on the second, straight across on the third, and on the fourth hand nobody passes at all and you play what you were dealt. Then the cycle starts again. Three players have no seat across from anyone, so their rotation is left, right, hold.

Once the passes have been picked up, whoever holds the 2 of clubs must lead it to the first trick. If the 2 of clubs was removed for the player count, the lowest club still in the pack leads instead: the 3 of clubs in a five-handed game, the 4 of clubs in a six-handed game. Play then goes clockwise, one card from each player.

You must follow the suit led if you hold anything in it. Only when you are void may you play something else, and then you may play any card you like subject to the two restrictions below. Because there is no trump suit, a trick is simply won by the highest card of the suit that was led. A card thrown off-suit cannot win the trick no matter how high it is. The winner gathers the trick face down and leads to the next one.

Two restrictions shape the whole hand.

First trick. No penalty card may be thrown on the opening trick. That rules out every heart and the queen of spades, even if you are void in clubs and would love to be rid of them. The only escape is a hand that contains literally nothing else, which almost never happens. Some groups relax this to bar hearts only and allow the queen on the first trick, so settle it before you deal.

Leading hearts. You may not lead a heart until hearts have been broken, and they are broken the first time somebody discards a heart on a trick led in another suit. The one exception is a player whose remaining cards are all hearts; they may lead one. The queen of spades is under no such restriction. She can be played whenever spades are led and discarded whenever you are void, and in the standard game putting her down does not break hearts. A good number of tables play that she does break them, which is worth agreeing on in advance.

A hand ends when all the cards are gone. Everyone turns their tricks face up, counts the penalty cards inside them, and the results go on the score sheet before the next player deals.

Goal & scoring

Hearts is a game you are trying to lose. The winner is whoever holds the fewest penalty points when the game ends.

Each heart you collect in a trick costs 1 penalty point and the queen of spades costs 13, so exactly 26 points are distributed every deal. Nothing else scores at all. The number of tricks you win is irrelevant; only what is inside them matters.

The exception is shooting the moon. If a single player takes all 13 hearts and the queen of spades in the same hand, the result inverts: the shooter scores nothing and every opponent is charged 26. Most groups let the shooter choose instead to subtract 26 from their own total, which is the better option when the opponents are already close to the finish or when you are sitting on zero and cannot go below it. The attempt is all or nothing. Let one heart escape to another player and you simply keep the pile you have gathered, which is normally a catastrophe.

Keep a running total for each player. The game ends at the end of the hand in which anyone reaches or passes 100 points, and the player with the lowest total at that moment wins. A target of 50 makes for a quicker game. If the two lowest totals are level, the usual fix is to keep dealing until the tie breaks.

Variants

Omnibus Hearts (Jack of Diamonds) — The jack of diamonds becomes a bonus card worth minus 10, so whoever takes it in a trick has 10 points struck off their score for that hand. It reshapes the deal completely, because diamonds are suddenly worth fighting for rather than dumping, and a shot at the moon now requires the jack as well as all the hearts and the queen of spades. Some groups use the 10 of diamonds for the same purpose.

Black Maria — The British three-handed form. Take out the 2 of clubs so that each of three players receives 17 cards. Three spades carry penalties instead of one: the queen is worth 13, the king 10 and the ace 7. Cards are passed three to the right only, there is no fixed opening lead, and many groups play it without any moon-shooting rule, so the hand is purely about dodging the black suit.

Cancellation Hearts — Built for six or more players using two full packs shuffled together. Identical cards cancel each other: if the same rank and suit appears twice in one trick, neither copy can win it, and the trick goes to the highest surviving card of the suit led. If every

candidate cancels out, nobody wins the trick; it stays on the table and is swept up along with all its penalty cards by whoever takes the next one.

Spot Hearts — Hearts are worth their pip value rather than a flat point each. The 2 through 10 count face value, the jack, queen and king count 10 apiece, the ace counts 15, and the queen of spades is raised to 25. That makes a single deal worth 124 points instead of 26, so the game target has to be scaled up to match, commonly to 500. Low hearts become throwaways and the ace of hearts becomes the card everyone is watching.

Shoot the Sun — An extra tier above shooting the moon that almost nobody achieves. Taking every trick in the hand, not merely every penalty card, is worth double the usual moon: 52 points against each opponent, or 52 struck off your own total, whichever you prefer. Groups that use it treat a failed sun as an ordinary moon attempt, so a player who wins twelve tricks and all the penalties still scores the plain moon.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Dice Game Depot, Trickster Cards, Cool Old Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Spades

Players	2-4 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	45-90 minutes
Difficulty	Medium
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

Spades is a four-player partnership game. Partners sit opposite each other so that the two sides alternate around the table. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Cards rank ace high down to 2 low in every suit, and spades are permanently trump. Nothing is turned or named to decide the trump suit; it is spades in every hand of every game.

Choose the first dealer by cutting, high card taking the deal, and move the deal one seat to the left after each hand. The dealer shuffles, offers a cut to the player on their right, then deals the whole pack out one card at a time clockwise starting with the player on their left, so everyone finishes with 13 cards. Each hand is therefore 13 tricks.

Set up the score sheet before you start. You need one column per partnership for points and, next to each, a small separate running tally of bags. The bag count carries across the entire game rather than resetting each hand, and forgetting to track it is the single most common way a Spades game goes wrong.

Play

Bidding comes first and takes exactly one round. Starting with the player to the dealer's left and moving clockwise, each player looks at their hand and names the number of tricks they expect to take, anything from 0 to 13. Bids do not have to increase, nobody may pass, and once a number is said it stands. You may not describe your hand or ask your partner anything, but every bid is public, so the last player to bid knows a great deal more than the first. The two partners' bids are added together into a single contract for the side: bids of 4 and 3 mean that partnership must take at least 7 tricks. Some groups impose a minimum team contract of 4, so check the house rule before you deal.

A bid of 0 is nil, a declaration that you personally will win no tricks whatsoever. Your partner bids normally and their number alone becomes the side's trick contract. Nil is scored separately and can succeed or fail independently of whether that contract is made.

Blind nil is a nil declared before you have looked at your cards at all, so it has to be announced as soon as the deal is finished. Most tables permit it only when your side is trailing by at least 100 points. After all four bids are in and before the first lead, the blind nil bidder pushes two cards face down across to their partner, who looks at them and passes two cards back face down. The point is to let the bidder shed two dangerous high cards and take low ones in exchange, while the partner absorbs the strength.

The player to the dealer's left leads to the first trick and may not lead a spade. Play continues clockwise. You must follow the suit led if you can; if you are void you may play any card at all, including a spade. A trick is won by the highest spade played to it, and if no spade was played, by the highest card of the suit led. A card of some third suit never wins. The winner of each trick leads to the next.

Spades may not be led until they have been broken, meaning until some spade has been played to a trick led in another suit, whether that was a deliberate ruff or a helpless discard. The one exception is a player holding nothing but spades, who may lead one. Nothing stops you trumping in the first time you are void; that is normally how spades get broken.

Everyone keeps their side's tricks together where both partnerships can count them. When the thirteenth trick is finished, count the tricks each side took and score the hand, then pass the deal to the left.

Goal & scoring

The first partnership to 500 points wins.

A side that takes at least as many tricks as it bid scores 10 points per trick bid, plus 1 point for each trick beyond the bid. Those extras are bags, also called sandbags, and the single point each one pays now is really a loan against a penalty later. Bid 7 and take 9 and you score 72: seventy for the contract and two for the bags.

A side that falls short is set and loses 10 points per trick bid, with no credit at all for the tricks it did win. Bid 7 and take 6 and you lose 70.

Bags accumulate for the whole game in their own tally. The moment a side reaches 10 bags, 100 points are deducted from that side's score and 10 comes off the bag count, leaving any surplus in place to start the next batch. Games are routinely decided by a sandbag penalty rather than by anything that happened in a trick, which is why deliberately underbidding a strong hand is a losing habit.

A successful nil is worth 100 points to the partnership, on top of whatever the partner's contract scores. A nil that wins even one trick costs 100. Blind nil doubles both numbers to plus or minus 200. When a nil fails, the standard treatment is that tricks won by the nil bidder do not help the partner make their contract but do count as bags for the side. Some groups let those tricks count toward the contract instead, so agree which before you start.

Play continues until a side is at 500 or more at the end of a hand. If both sides cross in the same hand, the higher total wins, and a genuine tie is broken by playing one more hand. Many groups also set a floor of minus 200, at which point that side loses outright.

Variants

Cutthroat (Solo) Spades — Partnerships are abolished and every player bids and scores for themselves, which turns the game into a running series of temporary alliances against whoever is ahead. Nil is usually reduced to 50 or 100 by agreement and the target is shortened, often to 200 or 300. Three-handed cutthroat is common too: remove the 2 of clubs so that 51 cards deal out to 17 each.

Suicide Spades — A partnership variant in which exactly one member of each side must bid nil on every single hand, with the partner carrying the whole trick contract alone and usually held to a minimum of 4. Partners decide between themselves who takes the nil, normally by an agreed signal or simply by whoever bids first. Scores swing enormously and the game becomes almost entirely about protecting a partner's nil.

Whiz and Mirror — Two restricted-bidding forms. In Whiz, each player must bid either nil or the exact number of spades in their hand, and no other bid is legal. Mirror is the stricter cousin: you must bid your spade count, and nil is only available to a player who was dealt no spades at all. Both remove almost all bidding judgement and shift the entire game onto the play of the cards.

Jokers and high deuces — Both jokers are added to the pack as the two highest trumps, a big joker and a little joker, and two low cards are removed so the deal still comes to 13 each. Many groups also promote one or more deuces into the trump suit above the ace of spades. The pecking order among the promoted deuces is the most argued-about detail in the whole game and varies from table to table, so establish it out loud before the first deal rather than mid-trick.

Two-handed Spades — Instead of a deal, the pack sits face down and the players alternate building their hands from it. On your turn you look at the top card and either keep it, in which case the next card goes to the discard pile unseen, or reject it, in which case you must take the card underneath. Continue until each player holds 13 cards; the rest are out of play. Bidding, the ban on leading spades before they are broken, and the scoring are all unchanged, and the game still runs to 500.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Trickster Cards, VIP Spades, Spades.co, DKM Games, MPL Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Whist

Also known as	Straight Whist, Partnership Whist, English Whist
Players	4 players
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	30-60 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Trick-taking

Setup

Whist is for exactly four players in two fixed partnerships, partners sitting opposite each other. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. In play the cards rank ace high down to 2 low.

Draw for partners and for the first deal at the same time. Spread the pack face down and have everyone take a card, counting the ace as low for this purpose only. The two lowest cards play against the two highest, and the lowest card of all deals first. Anyone who draws a duplicate rank or the bottom card of the pack draws again. After the first hand the deal moves one seat to the left.

The dealer shuffles, the player to the dealer's right cuts, and the whole pack is dealt out one card at a time clockwise, starting with the player on the dealer's left, so each hand holds 13. The final card of the deal, which belongs to the dealer, is turned face up on the table instead of being tucked into the hand. Its suit is trumps for that hand. It stays face up where everyone can see it until the dealer plays to the first trick, at which point the dealer takes it into hand and it becomes an ordinary card. From that moment on, remembering what it was is your own problem.

There is no bidding, no exchange of cards and no stock. As soon as the trump is turned, play begins.

Play

The player to the dealer's left leads any card at all to the first trick. Play then goes clockwise, one card from each player.

You must follow the suit that was led if you hold a card in it. Only when you are void may you play something else, and then you may play anything: a card of a third suit, which cannot win, or a trump, which can. A trick is taken by the highest trump in it, or if no trump was played, by the highest card of the suit led. The winner of the trick leads to the next one. All thirteen tricks are played out; there is no way to end a hand early, no concession and no discard pile.

How the tricks are stored matters more than beginners expect. One player from each partnership gathers every trick that side wins and stacks them face down in front of them, squared up and countable, rather than scattering them. Once a trick has been turned over and covered by the next one it is closed, and you are not allowed to look back through earlier tricks. Remembering what has gone is the whole skill of the game. Tables vary on whether the trick just completed may be re-examined before the next card is led; the strict rule is that only the trick currently in progress is public.

There is nothing to say during a hand. Whist is deliberately silent: no signalling, no remarks about your holding, no reaction to a partner's card. The turned trump and the fall of the cards are the only information anyone is entitled to, and drawing inferences from them is what you are there to do.

Playing off-suit when you could have followed suit is a revoke. Once it has been established, the standard remedy is that three tricks, or three points, are transferred from the offending side to their opponents at the end of the hand, and the offending side may not win the game on that deal. A revoke spotted and corrected before the trick is turned is usually just fixed on the spot, with the withdrawn card left face up as information for the opponents.

When the thirteenth trick is done, each side counts the tricks it won and the deal is scored. The deal then passes one seat to the left and the next hand is dealt.

Goal & scoring

Six tricks is the book and is worth nothing at all. Only tricks beyond six count, at 1 point each, which means a single hand is worth at most 7 points and both sides can never score in the same deal.

A game is 5 points in the standard British short whist. American play traditionally used 7, and older long whist ran to 9, which is where the game's reputation for endless sessions comes from. Whichever target you use, a rubber is the best of three games: the first side to win two games takes the rubber and adds 2 bonus points. If one side wins the first two games the third is not played. The rubber is settled by the difference between the two sides' point totals once the bonus is added.

Honours are the ace, king, queen and jack of the trump suit, and they score for having been dealt, not for having been won in tricks. A partnership dealt all four honours between its two hands scores 4 extra points at the end of the hand; three of the four scores 2. Two limits apply. Trick points are always counted before honours, so a side that reaches the target on tricks wins immediately. And a side already standing at 4 points towards a 5-point game may not score honours at all, on the principle that you should not be carried over the line by cards you merely held.

Many modern groups drop honours entirely and score tricks only, which makes the game a cleaner test of play. Decide which you are using before the first deal.

Variants

Bid Whist — The American partnership game built on whist, played hard and fast. Both jokers join the pack as a big and a little joker, each player is dealt 12 cards and six go face down as the kitty. Bidding runs from 3 to 7, meaning tricks above the book of six, and the winning bidder names trump or no-trump plus a direction: uptown, with the ranks in their usual order, or downtown, with them inverted so that after the ace the 2 is the strongest card and the king the weakest. The high bidder takes the kitty into hand and buries six cards face down, which count as a trick for that side. The bidding side scores tricks above six when it makes the contract and loses the value of its bid when it is set. Game is normally 7 points, and a side driven to minus 7 loses.

Knock-Out Whist — A short elimination game for three to seven players and a staple of British family card play. The first hand is seven cards each, with the top card of the undealt remainder turned to set trump. Tricks are played as in ordinary whist, but nothing is scored: any player who wins no tricks at all is knocked out. The player who took the most tricks deals the next hand and simply names trump after looking at their cards, with ties settled by a cut. Hands shrink by one card every round, seven down to one, and the last player standing wins. A common kindness is the dog's life, which lets the very first player eliminated stay in with a single card each round, played to whichever trick they choose.

German Whist — The two-player version, and the best-known one. Deal 13 cards each and put the remaining 26 face down as a stock with the top card turned up; its suit is trump for the entire hand. The first thirteen tricks are played for the stock rather than for score: the winner of each trick takes the exposed card, the loser takes the next card unseen, and a fresh card is turned. When the stock is exhausted both players hold 13 known-quality cards and play them out, and only these last thirteen tricks count, at 1 point for each trick above six. The first half is a card-drafting duel, the second half is pure technique.

Solo Whist — Four players, but each hand becomes an auction of individual contracts rather than a partnership affair. Cards are dealt in batches of three, then a final four, with the last card turned for trump. The bids in ascending order are: a proposal to take eight tricks with whoever accepts it, solo for five tricks alone in the turned trump, misere for losing every trick with no trump, abundance for nine tricks alone with a trump suit of your own choosing, open misere with your hand face up on the table, and a declared abundance for all thirteen. Results are settled in chips or units paid between the players hand by hand instead of accumulating on a score sheet.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Trickster Cards, Gamerules.com, Card Game Rules. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

RUMMY FAMILY

500 Rummy

Also known as	Rummy 500, 500 Rum, Pinochle Rummy
Players	2-8 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards) for 2 to 4 players; 2 decks shuffled together (104 cards) for 5 or more
Time	30-60 minutes
Difficulty	Medium
Category	Rummy family

Setup

Two to eight can play. Up to four players use a single 52-card pack; from five players up, shuffle two packs together and treat identical cards as interchangeable. Draw for the first deal, high card deals, and pass the deal to the left after each hand.

Deal 7 cards to each player, one at a time, clockwise from the dealer's left. In the two-player game deal 13 each instead. Place the remainder face down as the stock and turn its top card face up to begin the discard pile.

The discard pile is the heart of this game, so lay it out properly. Every discard goes on the pile offset from the one below it, fanned so that every card in the pile stays readable to everyone for the whole hand. Never square it up.

Aces work high or low but never both in the same run: A-2-3 and Q-K-A are legal, K-A-2 is not. Point values are what you will be adding up all game. An ace is worth 15, except when it is melded low in a sequence with the 2, where it counts 1. Kings, queens and jacks are 10 each. Every other card is worth its number. The player to the dealer's left starts.

Play

Melds are the usual two shapes: a set of three or four cards of the same rank, or a run of three or more cards of one suit in sequence. Unlike most rummies, melds are laid face up in front of you and stay yours, because at the end of the hand you are paid for the cards sitting on the table in front of you.

A turn is draw, then meld or lay off, then discard.

Drawing is where 500 Rummy differs from everything else in the family. You may take the top card of the stock, or you may reach into the discard pile and take any card in it, however deep. If you take a buried card, you must also take every card lying above it, and all of those go into your hand. The price of digging is an obligation: the card you reached for has to go straight onto the table this turn, either as part of a fresh meld you lay down or laid off onto a meld already showing. If you cannot place it immediately, you are not allowed to take it. Everything you scooped up on top of it is yours to keep and use later, or to be caught with.

That obligation is what makes the pile dangerous. A convenient discard early on can sit there for ten turns and then be dragged out from under a stack of eight cards by an opponent who wanted the one card underneath, and they get all eight.

Taking only the top card of the discard pile is the ordinary exception: you may take it without having to use it, exactly as in basic Rummy. Some groups apply the melding obligation to the top card as well, so settle it before you deal.

After drawing you may lay down as many melds as you like, and you may lay off cards onto any meld on the table, including melds belonging to your opponents. A card laid off is placed physically with the meld it extends, but it counts for you when scores are worked out, so feeding an opponent's run is a perfectly good way to bank points. Nothing has to be melded; a card kept in hand is only a liability at the end of the hand.

Finish by discarding one card face up, adding it to the fan.

The hand ends the moment one player has no cards left, whether their last card went down in a meld, was laid off, or was discarded. Everyone else is caught with whatever is still in hand.

A hand can also end without anyone going out. If the stock is empty and the player whose turn it is either cannot use the discard pile or chooses not to, the hand stops there and is scored as it stands. The discard pile is not turned over to make a new stock.

Goal & scoring

Score each hand separately, then keep a running total. The first player to reach 500 points wins. If two or more cross 500 in the same hand, the highest total takes it.

At the end of a hand, each player adds up the value of every card they have on the table, counting melds they laid down and cards they laid off onto anybody's meld, then subtracts the value of every card still in their hand. Aces are 15, or 1 when melded low against a 2; face cards are 10; everything else is its number.

The result can easily be negative, and negative scores really are subtracted from your running total, so a player caught with two aces and a couple of kings while holding nothing on the table goes backwards. That is the game's main pressure: melding early banks points but tells everyone what you are collecting, while sitting on cards to build a bigger play risks handing back more than you make.

Going out is worth having but carries no bonus in the standard game. Its value is that it ends the hand while everyone else is still holding cards.

Variants

Going-out bonus — Award the player who sheds their last card a flat bonus, most commonly 25 points, on top of their melds. Some tables also pay a bonus for going out in a single turn without having melded anything earlier in the hand. Either rule pushes play toward finishing hands quickly rather than grinding out meld points, which shortens the game considerably.

Deal and target adjustments — Plenty of groups deal 7 cards in the two-player game rather than 13, which makes for shorter, tighter hands with a deeper stock. Targets move too: 200 or 300 for a quick session, 1000 for a long one. Some also stop the game after a fixed number of deals and simply take the highest score.

Wild jokers — Add one or two jokers as wild cards that can stand for any card in a meld. Fix their value before you start, usually 15 or 20 points, counting for you on the table and against you in hand. A common companion rule lets a player who holds the natural card a joker is standing in for swap it into the meld and take the joker.

Michigan Rum — Played with 52 cards plus four jokers. The jokers are not wild here: they form a rank of their own and can only be melded as a group of three or four jokers together, never inside a run and never as a substitute. Each one is worth 20 points, which makes a set of jokers a large swing and being caught holding one expensive.

Persian Rummy — A four-player partnership relative using 52 cards and four jokers, with partners sitting opposite and their scores combined. Aces rank high only, so A-2-3 is not a run. Jokers count 20 apiece and are treated as their own rank rather than as wild cards. The game runs to 500 like the parent game, but partnership play changes the calculation on laying off, since helping your partner's meld helps your own side.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Cool Old Games, Game Rules. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Canasta

Also known as	Classic Canasta, Argentine Canasta
Players	2-4 players (best with 4)
Deck	2 standard decks plus 4 jokers (108 cards)
Time	60-120 minutes
Difficulty	Complex
Category	Rummy family

Setup

Four players in two fixed partnerships, partners sitting opposite each other. Shuffle two full 52-card decks together with four jokers: 108 cards. Cut for seats and first deal if you want a formal start, high card choosing; after that the deal passes clockwise each hand.

Deal 11 cards to each player, one at a time. Set the remaining cards face down in the middle as the stock and turn its top card face up beside it to begin the discard pile. If that upcard is a joker, a two, or a red three, turn another card on top of it and keep going until an ordinary card is showing. When that happens the pile starts the hand frozen; leave the wild card or red three sticking out crossways so everyone can see it stays frozen.

Before the first turn, every player puts any red threes from their dealt hand face up on the table in front of them and draws one replacement card from the stock for each, repeating if a replacement is itself a red three. The player to the dealer's left plays first.

Melds belong to the partnership, not the player, so keep them all in one group in front of one partner where both of you can reach them. Score is kept per partnership across as many deals as the game takes.

Play

Play goes clockwise, and a turn has three parts: take cards, meld if you want to, then discard one card face up on the pile. Melding is optional; taking and discarding are not.

Taking cards. Either draw the top card of the stock, or take the whole discard pile when you are entitled to. If you ever draw a red three, lay it down face up at once and draw another card to replace it.

Melds. A meld is three or more cards of the same rank, four through ace, and suits are irrelevant. Jokers and twos are wild and may be included, but a meld must always hold at least two natural cards and may never hold more than three wild cards. There are no sequences in Canasta. Your side may have only one meld of any given rank, so instead of starting a second you add to the one already on the table; either partner may add to any of the side's melds at any time. Cards on the table stay there and cannot be taken back into hand.

Threes. Red threes are never melded or held in hand; they sit face up in front of you doing nothing but scoring. Black threes may be melded only on the turn you go out, and only as a natural set of three or four with no wild card among them.

The first meld. Neither partner may put anything down until the side lays out melds whose card points reach a minimum set by their score at the start of the deal: 15 points if the score is below zero, 50 from 0 to 1,495, 90 from 1,500 to 2,995, and 120 at 3,000 or above. The whole requirement must be satisfied in one turn, and only the face value of the cards counts toward it. Red threes, canasta bonuses, and the going-out bonus do not help. If you make the initial meld

while taking the discard pile, the top card counts but the buried cards do not.

Taking the discard pile. You must use the top card immediately in a meld, and you always take the entire pile, never part of it. If the pile is not frozen against you, you may take it either by matching the top card with two natural cards of that rank from your hand, or by adding the top card to one of your side's existing melds, though not to one that is already a completed canasta of seven. If the pile is frozen against you, only the first way works: two natural cards of the same rank from your hand, melded together with the top discard. The pile is frozen for everyone once a wild card or red three lies buried in it, it is frozen against any side that has not yet made its initial meld, and it starts frozen if the first upcard was a wild card or red three. A frozen pile stays frozen until somebody takes it.

Black threes. Discarding a black three stops the next player from taking the pile no matter what they hold, but that block lasts one turn only and does not freeze the pile.

Canastas. A meld of seven or more cards is a canasta. Square it up and mark it with a red card on top if it is natural (no wilds) or a black card if it is mixed. You may keep adding cards afterwards, but laying a wild card on a natural canasta turns it into a mixed one.

Going out. You go out when you play the last card from your hand, whether as a discard, a new meld, or an addition to an existing one; finishing with a meld and no discard is allowed. Your side must have completed at least one canasta first. Before you touch anything on your turn you may ask your partner "may I go out?" and you are bound by the yes or no you get. Once you have melded or reached for the pile, you have given up the right to ask.

If your side has not melded yet and you draw from the stock into a hand you can lay down complete, canasta included, you may go out concealed on the spot without meeting the minimum count. Take the pile instead of drawing and that concession disappears: you must make the minimum, and the concealed bonus is not yours to claim.

When the stock runs out. If the last stock card is a red three, the player shows it and the hand ends immediately with no discard. Otherwise play continues with no stock: each player in turn must take the discard pile if its top card matches one of their side's melds and the pile is not frozen against them. The moment a player cannot do that, the hand stops there with nobody going out.

Goal & scoring

The partnership target is 5,000 points, played out over as many deals as it takes. Each deal is scored for the side as a whole.

Card values: jokers 50; twos and aces 20; kings, queens, jacks, tens, nines, and eights 10; sevens, sixes, fives, fours, and black threes 5. Add up everything your side has melded and subtract the value of every card still in either partner's hand.

Bonuses: 500 for each natural canasta, 300 for each mixed canasta, and 100 for going out. Going out concealed is worth 200 instead, which means laying down your whole hand in a single turn including a canasta, having never melded or added to your partner's melds earlier in the deal.

Red threes count 100 each for the side that laid them down, but only if that side made its initial meld; a side that never melded has the same 100 per red three deducted. Holding all four doubles it to 800 for or 800 against.

A deal can easily come out negative. Add each deal to the running total, since that total sets the next deal's minimum meld. The game ends when a side reaches 5,000 or more once a deal has been fully scored; if both sides cross 5,000 in the same deal, the higher total wins.

Variants

Two- and three-player Canasta — With two players, each is dealt 15 cards, a stock draw takes two cards rather than one (you still discard only one), everyone plays alone, and you need two canastas to go out. With three, deal 13 cards each and again play as individuals with the standard one-canasta requirement. Everything else follows the four-hand game.

Samba — Three decks and six jokers, 162 cards, for up to six players, dealt 15 each. Alongside ordinary rank melds you may build suited sequences; a run of seven cards in one suit is a samba, counts as a canasta for going out, and scores 1,500. Stock draws take two cards, going out needs two canastas, and the game runs to 10,000 with the initial meld minimum climbing to 150 once a side passes 7,000.

Hand and Foot — The most popular North American descendant, usually four to six decks with jokers. Each player gets two packets, commonly 11 cards as the hand and 13 as the foot; you play the hand first and only pick up the foot after emptying it. Melds are built toward books of seven, clean (no wilds) or dirty (with wilds), and going out typically demands a set quota of each, so a partnership cannot finish early on a thin table.

Modern American Canasta — The version most tournament and club play now uses. Initial melds must come entirely from the hand and must include a set of three or more natural cards, wild cards may be collected into a canasta of their own for a very large bonus (and a heavy penalty if left unfinished), and a partnership needs two canastas rather than one to go out. Melded ranks that can no longer be completed are treated as dead, which changes discard strategy considerably.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Hoyle's Rules of Games, Canasta League of America, GameRules.com. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Gin Rummy

Also known as	Gin
Players	2 players
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Rummy family

Setup

Gin Rummy is a two-handed game using a full 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Pick the first dealer by drawing from the shuffled pack: low card deals. After that the loser of each hand deals the next one, though plenty of players pass the deal to the winner instead, so agree which before you start.

The dealer shuffles, the opponent cuts, and ten cards go to each player one at a time, non-dealer first. Put the rest of the pack face down in the middle as the stock and turn its top card face up next to it. That upcard is the whole discard pile for now, and it leaves 31 cards in the stock.

Ranks run from ace low up to king, and they do not wrap. A-2-3 is a legal sequence; Q-K-A is not. For counting, an ace is 1 point, a numbered card is worth its number, and each jack, queen and king is 10. Keep your hand hidden. Nothing goes on the table until somebody ends the hand.

Play

There are two kinds of meld. A set is three or four cards of the same rank. A run is three or more cards of one suit in sequence. Each card can only work in one meld at a time, so holding 7♣ 7♠ 7♥ 8♥ 9♥ you may count the set of sevens or the heart run, not both. Everything outside your melds is deadwood, and its point total is what the whole game turns on.

The first turn has its own procedure. The non-dealer may take the upcard or refuse it. If they refuse, the dealer gets the same offer. If both refuse, the non-dealer opens by drawing the top card of the stock. Whoever takes a card then discards, and the players alternate normally from there.

An ordinary turn is two actions with nothing in between. Draw exactly one card, either the face-down top of the stock or the face-up top of the discard pile, then discard exactly one card face up onto the pile. You are back to ten cards at the end of every turn. You may not take the top discard and throw the same card straight back on that turn. Melds are never laid on the table during play; they stay in your hand until the hand ends.

You end the hand by knocking. You may knock on any turn, including your first, as long as your deadwood after discarding comes to 10 points or less. To do it, lay your final discard face down instead of face up, then spread your hand with the melds grouped separately from the deadwood and state your count. Knocking is optional. With a low count you are allowed to keep playing and hunt for a bigger score, at the risk of being knocked on first.

Zero deadwood is gin. Declare it the same way, spreading a hand in which every card is melded once the discard is gone.

Your opponent now spreads too. They arrange their own melds and then lay off: any loose card of theirs that fits one of your melds can be pushed onto it, adding a fourth card to a set or

extending either end of a run. Every card laid off comes out of their deadwood. Two restrictions matter. Nothing can be laid off against a gin hand, and nothing can ever be laid off onto the other player's deadwood.

Once the laying off is finished the two deadwood counts are compared, which decides who scores the hand.

The stock can run out. If a player draws the card that leaves only two cards in the stock and then discards without knocking, the hand is dead: neither player scores, and the same dealer deals again. Those last two stock cards are never drawn.

Goal & scoring

Hands are only steps toward the match target, which is 100 points.

A knock that survives scores the knocker the difference between the two deadwood counts. Knock with 6 against an opponent left holding 21 and you take 15. If the opponent's count after laying off is lower than yours, or exactly equal to it, they have undercut you: they score the difference plus a 25-point undercut bonus, and an equal count still counts as an undercut, worth the flat 25. Gin scores 25 plus every point of deadwood in the opponent's hand, and it can be neither laid off against nor undercut.

Keep running totals. The game ends as soon as either player's total reaches 100 at the end of a hand. Then add the bonuses: each player scores 25 for every individual hand they won, called a box or line bonus, and whoever reached 100 first adds a 100-point game bonus. If the loser never won a single hand, the winner doubles their entire total, game bonus included, which is known as a shutout, blitz or schneider. The higher total after bonuses wins the match, and the gap between the totals is the margin that gets settled.

Variants

Oklahoma Gin — The first upcard fixes the knock limit for the whole deal instead of the standard 10. If it is a 6, nobody may knock with more than 6 points of deadwood; face cards set the limit at 10, so an ordinary deal. Most tables add that an ace as the upcard means only gin ends the hand, and many use a spades-double rule where a spade upcard doubles everything scored that deal. This is the most widely played competitive form of the game.

Hollywood Gin — A scoring frame rather than a rules change: three games are tracked at once in three columns. The first hand a player wins is entered in their first column only, their second win goes into the first and second columns, and every win after that goes into all three. Each column is a separate race to 100 with its own bonuses, so a match runs longer and an early lead is worth much more.

Straight Gin — Knocking is abolished. The only way to end a hand is to go gin with all ten cards melded, which means no undercuts, no laying off and no partial scores. Hands run much longer and the whole discard-reading side of the game gets sharper, because you cannot bail out of a bad hand with a cheap knock.

Big Gin — An extra bonus recognised at many tables. If the card you draw gives you eleven melded cards with no discard needed, you declare big gin and score 31 plus your opponent's deadwood instead of the usual 25. Some groups score it at 25 like ordinary gin, so settle the number in advance.

Three- and four-handed gin — For three, the usual arrangement is that one player sits out each deal and the two active players use the standard rules, with the winner staying in and the

loser swapping out. For four, play as two partnerships: each player faces one opponent in a separate two-handed hand, then the partners' results for that round are combined and only the net difference is entered on the score sheet.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Cool Old Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Rummy

Also known as	Rum, Straight Rummy, Basic Rummy
Players	2-6 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Rummy family

Setup

Use one 52-card pack with the jokers removed. Any fair method picks the first dealer; drawing cards and giving the deal to the highest is common, and the deal then passes to the left after each hand.

How many cards you get depends on the size of the table. With two players, deal 10 each. With three or four, deal 7 each. With five or six, deal 6 each. Deal one card at a time, face down, clockwise, starting with the player on the dealer's left.

Put the rest of the pack face down in the middle as the stock, then turn its top card face up beside it to start the discard pile. Only the top card of that pile is ever available, so keep it squared up rather than spread.

Aces are low. A-2-3 is a run and Q-K-A is not, unless you agree otherwise before the first deal. For scoring, an ace is 1 point, each numbered card is worth its number, and a jack, queen or king is 10. The player to the dealer's left takes the first turn.

Play

You are trying to get rid of every card in your hand by arranging them into melds. A set is three or four cards of the same rank, such as three nines. A run is three or more cards of one suit in sequence, such as 5♠ 6♠ 7♠. A card can only belong to one meld at a time.

A turn has three parts and always happens in this order.

First, draw. Take either the top card of the stock, sight unseen, or the top card of the discard pile, which everyone can see. You draw exactly one card, and you may not dig deeper into the discard pile.

Second, meld if you want to. Lay any complete set or run from your hand face up in front of you. You may also lay off: add a card to any meld already on the table, yours or an opponent's, by putting a fourth card on a set or extending either end of a run. Laying off is how single cards get used up late in a hand, and the card belongs to the meld it joins, not to the player who originally laid it. Melding is always optional, even when you can. Holding a completed meld back keeps your options open but risks getting caught with it.

Third, discard. Put one card face up on the discard pile. That ends your turn and passes play to the left. The one thing you cannot do is take the top discard and immediately throw the same card back.

Two points worth agreeing before you deal, because tables differ. Some groups let you lay down as many melds as you like on a turn while others allow only one per turn, and some require you to have melded something of your own before you are allowed to lay off on other players. The looser version of both is the more common modern game.

The hand ends when somebody goes out, which means playing their last card. You can go out by melding, by laying off, or by discarding your final card, and any mix of those in one turn. In the basic game you do not need to keep a card back for a final discard, though a good number of households insist on it.

If nobody has gone out by the time the stock is empty, turn the discard pile over to make a fresh stock, leaving its top card face up as the new discard, and carry on. Some players shuffle it first. If the deck cycles again with no progress, most groups simply end the hand and score it where it stands.

Going out in a single turn, with no previous melds or lay-offs at all, is going rummy and pays double. To do it you must put your entire hand down on one turn, having laid nothing on the table earlier in the deal.

Goal & scoring

The object of each hand is to be first to shed every card. The object of the game is to reach an agreed target, most often 100 or 500, over as many hands as it takes; a fixed number of deals works just as well as long as everyone agrees before the first shuffle.

When a player goes out, everyone else counts the cards still in their hand. Melds already on the table do not count for or against anybody, and neither do cards you laid off. Aces are 1, numbered cards are face value, and jacks, queens and kings are 10 each. The winner of the hand scores the sum of everything all the other players are left holding.

Going rummy doubles the whole amount collected for that hand.

The common alternative is penalty scoring: instead of the winner collecting, each losing player writes down the value of their own leftover cards as a plus score, the winner writes zero, and the game runs until someone crosses an agreed limit, at which point the lowest total wins.

Variants

Block Rummy — The discard pile is never recycled. When the stock runs out and the next player does not want the top discard, the hand stops there and nobody goes out. Everyone counts the cards in their hand as penalty points, including the player who would otherwise have won. It makes hoarding a big hand far more dangerous and speeds the game up noticeably.

Boathouse Rum — A sharper two-player version. If you take the top discard you must then draw a second card, either the next discard or the top of the stock, but you still discard only one, so your hand grows. An ace may be used high or low, but not both ends at once, and it costs 11 points if you are caught holding it. You may not meld or lay off at all until the turn on which you go out, so every hand is played entirely from concealment.

Knock Rummy — Also called Poker Rum. Nothing is laid on the table during play. Instead, any player may end the hand on their turn by discarding face down and knocking, then spreading their hand. Everyone reveals, counts their unmelded cards, and the lowest count wins the difference from each of the others. Knocking with a count that turns out not to be lowest is punished with a penalty, so the bluffing element sits in when you dare to stop the hand.

Wild cards — Add one or two jokers, or nominate a rank such as deuces, as wild cards that can stand in for anything in a meld. A common accompanying rule lets a later player swap the natural card for a wild one sitting in a meld on the table and take the wild card into hand. Wilds usually carry a heavy penalty value, often 15 or 20 points, if you are caught holding one at the end of a hand.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Denexa Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

MATCHING & COLLECTING

Casino

Also known as	Cassino
Players	2-4 players (best with 2)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards)
Time	20-40 minutes
Difficulty	Medium
Category	Matching & collecting

Setup

Two to four players and one standard 52-card deck. Despite the name, nothing is bet and nobody banks: this is a fishing game, where you catch cards off the table with cards from your hand. It plays best head to head. With four, partners sit opposite each other and pool their captures; with three, everyone plays alone.

Pick a first dealer however you like — low card on a cut is the usual method — and pass the deal to the left after each round.

Deal in twos. Two cards to each player, then two face up to the middle, then two more to each player and two more face up. Everyone ends up holding four cards, with four lying face up in the centre. Put the rest of the deck face down beside the dealer. It is used to top hands up later; no further cards are ever added to the table.

Card values in play: an ace is 1 and numeral cards are worth their pips, which includes the two of spades counting 2 and the ten of diamonds counting 10, regardless of what they are worth at scoring time. Jacks, queens and kings have no numeric value and never take part in any addition.

Each player (or partnership) keeps captured cards in a face-down pile, out of play until the round is scored. The player to the dealer's left starts.

Play

On your turn you play exactly one card from your hand, face up, and it must do one of three things: capture, build, or trail. Then play passes to the left. Never more than one card, never fewer.

Capturing. Put your card down and take the table cards it wins, adding them and it to your capture pile.

- By rank: any table card of the same rank as the card you played. A numeral card takes every match at once, so a 7 collects both 7s if two are showing. A face card takes only one matching face card per turn, even when two or three of its rank are sitting there.
- By sum: any group of numeral table cards whose values add up to your card. A 9 can lift a 4 and a 5, or an ace, a 3 and a 5. Face cards can never be part of a sum.
- Several at once: a single card may take a matching rank, one or more separate summing groups, and any build worth that number, all in the same turn. A 9 could take a loose 9, a 6 with a 3, and a build of nine together.

You are never obliged to take everything on offer. Take whichever legal captures you want.

Building. Add a card from your hand to one or more table cards, push them into a pile, and announce what the pile is now worth: "building eight." You must keep a card in hand capable of

capturing that number, and you may not build using only cards already on the table.

A single build is one combination adding to the announced number, such as a 3 and a 5 built to eight. Any player holding the right card may capture it, and any player may raise it by adding a card from hand — laying an ace on a build of eight and announcing nine takes it over, so long as they hold a nine.

A multiple build is two or more separate groups worth the same number stacked together, for example an 8 from hand laid on a 5-and-3 build, still worth eight. Once a build is multiple its value is fixed; nobody may raise it, and only a card of that number takes it. Court cards can never go into a build.

While you own a build on the table you may not trail. On each of your turns you must capture, add to a build, or start another build, and if you can do none of those, you must capture your own build.

Trailing. When you cannot capture or build, or simply prefer not to, lay a card face up on the table by itself. It becomes a loose card that anyone may take.

Sweeps. A capture that clears the table completely is a sweep. Turn one card in your capture pile face up to record it. The player after a sweep faces an empty table and can only trail.

Refilling and the last trick. When every hand is empty, the dealer gives four more cards to each player from the stock, two at a time, and adds nothing to the table. Play carries on the same way. The dealer should announce "last" when dealing the final round so nobody is surprised. After the very last card is played, whoever made the most recent capture sweeps up whatever is still lying on the table — but that is not counted as a sweep. A real sweep made with the final card of the deal does count.

Goal & scoring

Casino is usually played to 21 points across several rounds. Eleven is the common short target, and some groups simply play one round for the points on offer and call it a game.

At the end of each round, sort your captured cards and score:

- 3 points for taking the most cards. If the split is exactly 26 apiece, nobody scores it.
- 1 point for taking the most spades. There are thirteen, so this cannot be tied.
- 2 points for big casino, the ten of diamonds.
- 1 point for little casino, the two of spades.
- 1 point for each ace, four in total.
- 1 point for each sweep.

That is 11 fixed points a round, plus however many sweeps were made.

If two players pass the target in the same round, settle it by counting in the traditional fixed order — most cards, most spades, big casino, little casino, then the aces of spades, clubs, hearts and diamonds — and the first to reach the target wins. Sweeps are earned during play rather than at the count, so they sit on the score before that sequence begins.

Variants

Royal Casino — Court cards get numeric values and join the arithmetic: jack 11, queen 12, king 13. They can be built, captured by sums, and used to capture combinations, which makes builds far more flexible. The ace is usually worth 1 or 14 at the discretion of whoever plays it.

Everything else follows the standard game.

Spade Casino — The spade suit carries the scoring instead of a single point for holding most of it. Each spade you capture is worth a point on its own, the jack of spades scores an extra one, and the rest of the values are unchanged. Game is 61 and is normally pegged on a cribbage board as the points come in, since the totals move so much faster.

Draw Casino — The undealt cards stay as a face-down stock and you draw one after every play to keep your hand at four, so there are no separate deals and no announced last round. Cards simply run out when the stock does. It removes most of the counting advantage of the standard game, since you cannot track how many rounds remain.

Partnership Casino — The standard four-handed form: two teams of two, partners facing each other across the table, captures thrown into one shared pile and scored as a unit. A build made by one partner may be captured by the other, so builds become a way of passing information and setting your partner up rather than a private plan.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Britannica, Hoyle's Rules of Games, Denexa Games, GameRules.com.
Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Cribbage

Also known as	Crib, Six-card Cribbage, Noddy
Players	2-4 players (best with 2)
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), plus a cribbage board or pencil and paper
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Medium
Category	Matching & collecting

Setup

Two players, one standard 52-card deck, and a cribbage board with two pegs each. Cards rank king high down to ace low, and for counting purposes an ace is 1, a face card is 10, and everything else is worth its index.

Cut for the deal: low card deals first, and the deal alternates every hand afterwards. Cutting for the first deal matters, because the dealer's edge is real and it swaps every deal.

Deal six cards to each player, one at a time, and put the rest of the deck face down to one side. Look at your six and lay two of them face down in a pile off to the dealer's side of the board. Those four cards are the crib, an extra hand that the dealer alone will score at the end of the deal, so the non-dealer throws to it defensively and the dealer throws to it generously. Neither player looks at the crib until the hands have been played out.

With both hands down to four cards and the crib set aside, the non-dealer cuts the deck and the dealer turns up the top card of the bottom portion, laying it face up on the deck. This is the starter, and it is shared: both hands and the crib count it as a fifth card at the end of the deal, though it is not used during the play. If the starter is a jack, the dealer immediately pegs 2 for his heels.

Both pegs start off the board. Score by leapfrogging the back peg ahead of the front one, so the gap always shows what you just scored.

Play

A deal has two phases: the play, usually called pegging, and then the show.

The play. The non-dealer leads a card face up in front of them and announces its value. The dealer plays a card and announces the new running total, and so on alternately, each of you keeping your own played cards in a personal row rather than a shared pile so the hands can be picked up again afterwards. The running total may never exceed 31.

You peg immediately as you lay a card down: 2 for taking the total to exactly 15; 2 for taking it to exactly 31; 2 for playing a card of the same rank as the one just played; 6 for a third card of that rank; 12 for a fourth. A run of three or more scores a point per card, counting backwards through the cards played since the last reset, in any order, as long as no unrelated card sits among them. Runs can be lengthened by either player: after 6, 4, 5 has scored three, a 3 or a 7 scores four. Suits are irrelevant during the play, and a pair is only a pair if the card just before it matched, not merely if the rank appeared earlier.

Go. If you cannot play a card without pushing the total past 31, say "go". Your opponent then keeps playing on their own for as long as they legally can. When nobody can play, whoever laid the last card pegs 1 for the go, or 2 instead if the total landed exactly on 31. The count then resets to zero and the player who did not lay that last card leads to the new count, with

whatever cards remain. This is the same point people call "last card": when both hands run dry, the player who laid the final card of the deal takes that single point, or 2 if it happened to make 31. It is one point, not a go point plus a last-card point.

The show. When both hands are empty, everyone picks their four cards back up and scores them together with the starter, treating it as a fifth card. Counting happens in a fixed order and must be done aloud: the non-dealer's hand first, then the dealer's hand, then the dealer's crib. That order decides close games, because play stops the moment a peg reaches the game hole. A non-dealer sitting on 118 counts first and can win before the dealer's hand and crib are ever counted.

The deal then passes and the next hand begins. Points are pegged as they are earned, never totalled at the end, and a peg once advanced cannot be moved back; if you overlook points and start the next stage, they are lost, unless you are playing muggins, in which case your opponent takes them.

Goal & scoring

First to 121 points wins, which is twice around a standard board plus the game hole. Points are pegged continuously, and the game ends instantly when a peg reaches 121, mid-count if necessary.

A hand or crib is scored as those four cards plus the starter, and every scoring combination that can be made from those five counts, including the same card used again and again in different combinations:

- Fifteen: any group of cards adding to exactly 15 scores 2, and you count every distinct group.
- Pair: 2 per pair. Three of a kind is three separate pairs and so scores 6; four of a kind scores 12.
- Run: 3 or more in consecutive rank scores 1 per card, and each distinct run counts. A double run of three (a run plus a duplicated rank) scores 8 in all, since it is two runs of three plus a pair.
- Flush: 4 if all four cards in hand share a suit, 5 if the starter matches too. In the crib only the full five-card flush scores; four matching crib cards on their own are worth nothing.
- His nobs: 1 for holding the jack of the starter's suit, in hand or in the crib.
- His heels: 2 to the dealer, pegged at once, when the starter turned is a jack.

The highest possible hand is 29: three fives and the jack matching a starter five. Zero-point hands are common enough to have their own name, a nineteen.

In match play, a loser still short of 91 is skunked and the win is usually worth double; short of 61 is a double skunk.

Variants

Five-card cribbage — The original English form. Five cards are dealt to each player, both discard two, and hands of only three are played, so pegging is short and the crib carries a lot of the scoring. Game is 61, once around the board, and the non-dealer pegs 3 straight away at the start of the game as compensation for not having the first crib.

Three-handed cribbage — Each player is dealt five cards and discards one to the crib. Because that leaves the crib a card short, the dealer also deals one card face down to it straight off the deck. Everyone plays alone on a triangular board, the deal rotates left, and the player to

the dealer's left leads the first card and counts first at the show.

Partnership cribbage — The standard four-player game: two teams of two, partners facing each other, one peg line per team. Deal five cards each and everyone discards one to the dealer's crib. Play proceeds clockwise around the table, and either partner's points advance the shared peg. First side to 121 wins.

Muggins — An optional rule that punishes sloppy counting. If you finish counting a hand or crib and have missed points, your opponent may call "muggins" and peg those points instead. It is common in club and tournament play and worth agreeing on before the first deal rather than after somebody undercounts.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, American Cribbage Congress, Masters of Games. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Old Maid

Also known as	Scabby Queen, Black Peter, Schwarzer Peter, Old Bachelor
Players	2-8 players (best with 4)
Deck	1 standard deck with one queen removed (51 cards)
Time	10-20 minutes
Difficulty	Simple
Category	Matching & collecting

Setup

Take a standard 52-card deck and pull out one queen, setting it aside face down where nobody can see which one it was. That leaves 51 cards: twelve ranks still complete at four cards each, and queens reduced to three. Everything can be matched into 25 pairs except one queen, which has nothing to go with. That leftover queen is the old maid.

Choose a dealer any way you like; cutting for high card works, and the deal passes to the left between games. Shuffle and deal the entire pack out one card at a time, going clockwise. It will not come out even. Some players end up with one card more than others, and that is fine and does not affect play.

Everyone picks up their hand and looks at it privately. Before the first turn, each player lays down every pair they were dealt, face up in front of them, and takes no further interest in those cards. A pair is two cards of the same rank; suit and colour are irrelevant. If you hold three of a kind, you may only discard two of them and must keep the third. If you hold all four of a rank, put down two pairs.

Play

Play moves clockwise. The dealer goes first, though many families instead start with the player to the dealer's left; agree before you begin, since it changes nothing but who is exposed first.

On your turn you hold your hand out to the player on your left, spread face down like a fan so the backs are toward them and no faces show. That player takes one card of their choice, blind, and adds it to their hand. If the card they drew makes a pair with something they already hold, they lay that pair down face up at once. If it does not, they simply keep it.

The player who just drew then becomes the one who offers, fanning their own hand face down to the player on their left, and so on around the table. Cards therefore move steadily around the circle, each player always drawing from the neighbour on their right and always offering to the neighbour on their left.

Shuffling your hand before you offer it is the whole skill of the game. Keeping the old maid in one spot, glancing at it, or holding it slightly proud will get it read instantly, especially by children, who are usually better at spotting a tell than adults expect.

When a player's hand becomes empty, whether by laying down a pair or by having their last card drawn away, that player is out and safe. Skip them from then on. Offering and drawing simply pass to the next player who still holds cards, closing the circle up as it shrinks.

The hand ends when every card that can be paired has been paired. At that point exactly one card is left in the game, held by exactly one player: the odd queen. There is no scoring round and no way to unload it once you are the last player holding cards, so the ending is always the same shape.

Goal & scoring

Your aim is to get rid of every card in your hand and, above all, not to be the one holding the unmatched queen at the end.

There is no point scoring. Everyone who empties their hand wins equally, and the single player left with the old maid loses that hand. Position or order of going out does not matter; being out first carries no extra credit.

Because the loser is decided entirely by blind draws and by how well people disguise their hands, results swing wildly from deal to deal. Groups that want a longer session usually play a fixed number of hands and count how many times each person was stuck as the old maid, with the lowest count winning overall. Some play instead until one player has been the old maid three times and is out.

Variants

Dedicated Old Maid deck — Purpose-made children's decks replace the standard pack with illustrated character pairs plus one unpaired Old Maid card. Play is identical, but the matching is by picture rather than rank, which makes it far easier for very young players who cannot yet read card ranks reliably.

Joker as the odd card — Instead of removing a queen, leave the deck complete at 52 and add a single joker, giving 53 cards. All four queens stay in and can be paired; the joker is the card nobody wants. This is how the game is usually played in Japan, where it is known as babanuki, and it saves you from fishing a card out of the pack.

Scabby Queen — A British version in which three queens are removed so that the queen of spades is the doomed card, and the loser takes a forfeit. Traditionally the loser cuts cards from the pack and is rapped across the knuckles with the deck a number of times set by the card drawn. Most groups now drop the physical penalty and keep only the named target card.

Black Peter — The continental European form, called Schwarzer Peter in Germany and Svarte Petter or Svarteper in Scandinavia. A jack, usually the jack of spades, is the unpairable card rather than a queen, and the loser is often marked with a smudge of soot or a drawn-on moustache. Many countries sell dedicated Black Peter decks in the same spirit as illustrated Old Maid packs.

Any odd card — Remove a card at random, face down, without anyone seeing which one it was, so nobody knows what the unpairable card is until the hand is nearly over. This kills the strategy of tracking one known queen and stops experienced players from reading the table so easily. A Philippine version, ungguy-ungguyan, is played this way.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Gambiter, Card Game Wiki, Ducksters. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.